MOREH NEVUCHIM

# Whose Face Did Hashem Pass? Ram, Nasa & the 13 Attributes, Part 1

**Given Tuesday 13 October 2026** · Moreh Nevuchim I:20-21

**Sefer:** Moreh Nevuchim (Rambam), Chelek Aleph — Rabbi Chaim Makbili's Hebrew edition / Sefaria

**Chapters:** I:20 — the terms **רם** and **נשא**; I:21 — **עבר** (Hashem "passing"), introduction only

**Topic:** Why the Rambam splits רם and נשא into separate halves of the chapter; *being* exalted versus *being lifted up*; why נשא can also mean to forgive and to count; **רם ונשא** in davening and in Kaddish; a first glimpse of negative theology; reading Yeshayahu's vision with everything we have learned; and the groundwork for **ויעבר ה' על פניו ויקרא**: the story, the revision, and four questions to hold on to

**Schedule note:** The Moreh continues every Tuesday through the winter. Chapter 21 is a major chapter and will take several shiurim; tonight covered only its introduction. **The Rabbi asks everyone to listen to this whole shiur before next week**, because next week goes straight into Chapter 21 and cannot be followed without this introduction.

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## Recap — Chapters 18 and 19

**Chapter 18:** the three verbs **קרב, נגש, נגע** can mean physically approaching or touching, but can also describe **intellectual or spiritual closeness**. Used of Hashem, they always mean drawing closer to Him through understanding, prophecy, tefillah, or seeking refuge in Him; never physical proximity.

**Chapter 19: מלא** can mean a physical filling or the completion of a period of time, but used of Hashem it always means **perfection**. **מלא כל הארץ כבודו** means the universe displays excellence, perfection and wisdom, through which we come to know Hashem. **וכבוד ה' מלא את המשכן** means the Mishkan was a setting in which one could experience the divine and see Hashem's glory.

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## Chapter 20 — רם and נשא

## Why These Two Words, and Why Now?

This continues the verse we keep returning to, the opening of **Yeshayahu 6**:

**בשנת מות המלך עזיהו, ואראה את אדנ-י ישב על כסא רם ונשא, ושוליו מלאים את ההיכל.**

Chapter 19 took **מלא** from this verse. Chapter 20 now takes **רם** and **נשא**. Literally: *elevated* and *lifted up*.

## Part 1 — רם

**רם הוא מונח רב משמעי:**

**משמעות רום המקום** — physical elevation;

**ומשמעות רום המעלה, כלומר הגדולה והכבוד והעוז** — elevation in **status**: greatness, honour, strength.

### Meaning 1 — physical height

**ותרם התבה מעל הארץ** (this week's parashah, Noach)

The ark was lifted above the earth by the floodwaters. A physical elevation.

### Meaning 2 — elevation of status

**הרימותי בחור מעם** (Tehillim)

"I raised up a young man from the people": David HaMelech. Hashem did not physically lift him; He made him important and made him king.

**יען אשר הרימותיך מתוך העפר** (of Yeravam) and **אשר הרימותיך מתוך העם** (of Ba'asha)

"I raised you up": not from a lower place to a higher one, but in status.

**A reminder:** the verse actually says **מן העפר**, not **מתוך העפר**. As we said last week, the Rambam quotes verses from memory, so small variations creep in.

### רם used of Hashem

**וכל ביטוי של הרמה שנאמר על ה' — המשמעות השנייה זו.**

Whenever רם is used of Hashem, it must mean the second meaning. For example:

**רומה על השמים אלהים, על כל הארץ כבודך** (Tehillim)

"Be exalted above the heavens, O God." It cannot be physical: as we learned last week, there is no difference in closeness to Hashem whether one is on earth or on the ninth sphere. David is asking Hashem to **bring justice upon the wicked** who have troubled him, so that people see that He is there. **Through exacting justice, He will be seen to be in charge of the universe** — that is the "exaltation".

## Part 2 — נשא

### Why does the Rambam split the chapter in two?

Notice something. Until now, whenever the Rambam discussed several related verbs in one chapter, he **grouped them together**:

- **Chapter 4:** ראה, חזה, הביט — three kinds of seeing, but all seeing, treated together.
- **Chapter 18:** קרב, נגע, נגש — slightly different, but all physical or intellectual proximity, treated together.

**Here he divides the chapter: first רם, then נשא.** Why? Because there is a **fundamental difference** between them:

| | רם | נשא |
|---|---|---|
| Part of speech | **Adjective** | **Verb** |
| Meaning | **Is** high, elevated, exalted | **To lift up**: to move something from low to high |
| Source of the height | **Intrinsic** — רם בעצמו | **From someone else** — נשא על ידי אחרים |

The **Malbim** says this explicitly (see below). And every verse the Rambam brings for נשא is a verse of *lifting up*.

**This is why review matters.** You can only see what the Rambam is doing here if you remember how he handled Chapters 4 and 18. Everything ties into everything else. Those listening on YouTube: go over the shiurim.

## The two meanings of נשא

**משמעות של רום המקום** — physical lifting, from lower to higher;

**ומשמעות של רום המעלה והגדולה והתרוממות המעלה** — raising in status: taking someone low and bringing him up.

**Meaning 1 — physical:**

**וישאו את שברם על חמריהם** (Mikeitz)

The brothers lifted their grain from the ground onto their donkeys.

**Meaning 2 — status:**

**ותנשא מלכתו** (Balak)

Bilam's curse-turned-blessing: there will be times when Israel's kingdom is low, in exile, far down — but it will always be **lifted up** again. Not physically: its status rises, from low to high.

**וינטלם וינשאם כל ימי עולם** (Yeshayahu)

Hashem will always take us up and raise our status.

**ומדוע תתנשאו על קהל ה'?** (Korach)

Korach's complaint: **כי כל העדה כלם קדשים ובתוכם ה'** — we are all on the same level, all holy. So why do you **lift yourselves up** above everyone?

## Why נשא means so many things

The Rabbi has long wondered how one root, **נ־ש־א**, can mean so many different things:

| Meaning | Example |
|---|---|
| To lift up | ותנשא מלכתו |
| To **forgive** | **נשא עון ופשע וחטאה ונקה** (said again and again on Yom Kippur; Chapter 21) |
| To **count** | **נשא את ראש בני גרשון** (Naso) |
| Perhaps also to **appoint** | (the Rabbi couldn't recall an example offhand) |

**His suggestion:** the core of נשא is **taking something from low to high**. When you **count** or **appoint** someone, you lift them up conceptually: you give them significance. When you **forgive** someone, they were low in your books, and you raise them up in your mind. So all the meanings are one meaning: moving from low to high — unlike רם, which is *already* high.

## נשא used of Hashem

**וכל לשון נשיאה המיוחסת לו יתעלה — פירושו כזה.**

Whenever נשא is used of Hashem, it must mean the second meaning, status.

**הנשא שופט הארץ, השב גמול על גאים** (Tehillim; said every morning)

Does it mean "God, raise Yourself from low to high in space"? No. At the moment it looks as though there is no justice, as though God has abandoned the world. **Judge the earth, bring justice to the wicked — and so You will be raised up**, conceptually, from low to high in status.

## כי כה אמר רם ונשא — Why Both Together?

**כי כה אמר רם ונשא, שכן עד וקדוש שמו: מרום וקדוש אשכון, ואת דכא ושפל רוח** (Yeshayahu 57)

**רוממות וגדולה ועוז, לא עילוי מקום.**

Status, not place. But if רם and נשא are fundamentally different, **why does the verse put them together?**

**Notice: whenever the two appear together, רם always comes first.** In Shacharit, just before the Amidah:

**על זאת שבחו אהובים ורוממו לאל, ונתנו ידידים זמירות שירות ותשבחות, ברכות והודאות, למלך אל חי וקים, רם ונשא, גדול ונורא...**

**The meaning:** Hashem is **רם**, intrinsically exalted. And He is also **נשא**: He becomes *lifted up*, at least **in our minds**, through our worship and service of Him. Obviously Hashem does not need our prayers. But when we pray, we lift Him up in our own understanding; asking someone for something is an acknowledgement of them.

**And in Kaddish:**

**יתברך וישתבח ויתפאר ויתרומם ויתנשא ויתהדר...**

**ויתרומם** — You are already up. **ויתנשא** — our job is to "carry You up", from low to high. Hashem needs no one to carry Him; but conceptually, in our minds, He is both **רם** in Himself and **נשא** through us.

**The Rabbi's illustration:** *"Some are born great, and some have greatness thrust upon them."* **רם** is born to greatness. **נשא** has greatness thrust upon it — lifted up by others. Hashem's true essence is beyond anything we can understand, but in our minds, at least, we can lift Him up.

## A Paragraph on Negative Theology (Developed Much Later)

The Rambam closes the chapter with one paragraph that he will develop at length at the **end of Section 1**:

**שמא יקשו עליך דברי — רוממות, מעלה, גדולה ועוז — ותאמר: כיצד זה נותן אתה משמעויות רבות למשמעות אחת?**

**The question:** I have defined רם and נשא using several words: *exaltedness, elevation, greatness, strength*. How can one word have four definitions?

**עוד יבואר לך שהשם יתעלה, אצל המשיגים השלמים, אין לו תארים, ושכל התארים המרובים הללו האמורים עליו... כולם חוזרים למשמעות אחת, ומשמעות זו היא עצמותו, ולא שום דבר חוץ מזה.**

**אך המטרה בפרק הזה אינה אלא שאין פירושם [של רם ונשא] מקום אלא מעלה.**

**The answer:** those who truly understand Hashem know that **He has no attributes**. All the many descriptions used of Him **come back to one thing: His essence**, and nothing outside it. I will explain this later. **My only aim in this chapter is to show that רם and נשא mean status, not place.**

### An example of the Introduction's fifth reason

This is a case of what the Rambam told us in the **Introduction**: of the **seven reasons** an author may appear to contradict himself, one (the Rabbi thought the fifth) is that he **teaches something not fully precise in order to make a point, and clarifies it later**. The Rambam's purpose in these first fifty-odd chapters is to

remove corporeality from the problematic terms. So for now he uses rich language (רוממות, גדולה, עוז) to drive the point home, knowing he will refine it later. He cannot give everything in one chapter.

### Negative theology in a sentence

Later we will learn that **no word truly describes Hashem**, because the finite human mind can never describe the infinite. However many words we use — **גדול, גבור, נורא, רחום וחנון, ארך אפים** — they do not describe Him. When we say **אל רחום וחנון**, what we can actually grasp is that **He is *not not* merciful**. We can understand negatives, because negatives are limits, and limits are within our grasp. **Positive attributes of God are unlimited and undefined**, and a finite mind, however clever, cannot hold them.

Don't worry if that isn't fully clear yet; we will go into it in great detail later. For now: don't be troubled that I am using many words for one verb. They all come back to one thing, His essence, His unity.

## Chapter 20 — Summary

Continuing from **מלא** in Chapter 19, the Rambam explains **רם** and **נשא**. Both can mean physical height or elevation of **status**, and used of Hashem both always mean status, never place. But the Rambam **splits the chapter in two**, unlike his earlier groupings, because **רם is an adjective — intrinsically high — while נשא is a verb — lifted from low to high by someone else**; hence נשא can also mean to forgive and to count. Hashem is **רם** in Himself and **נשא** in our minds through our worship: hence **רם ונשא, ויתרומם ויתנשא**, always with רם first. And the many words the Rambam uses to define these terms will later be shown to refer back to one thing, **Hashem's essence**, which no attribute can describe.

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## Revision — Reading Yeshayahu 6:1 with Twenty Chapters Behind Us

Before starting Chapter 21, the Rabbi stopped to read the verse we have been circling, to show why review matters:

**בשנת מות המלך עזיהו, ואראה את אדנ-י ישב על כסא רם ונשא, ושוליו מלאים את ההיכל.**

**How many of its words have we now studied in the Moreh?**

**Avi:** six. **The Rabbi:** "Very good."

| # | Word | Chapter | Meaning with Hashem |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | **ואראה** | 4 | Intellectual seeing, a prophetic perception |
| 2 | **ישב** | 11 | Permanence, stability, constancy |
| 3 | **כסא** | 9 | Majesty; His involvement and השגחה |
| 4 | **רם** | 20 | Intrinsically exalted |
| 5 | **ונשא** | 20 | Lifted up — in the prophet's mind |
| 6 | **מלאים** | 19 | Perfection |

**The Malbim** on this verse goes through it exactly this way, drawing on the Moreh:

> **פעל ראיה לה' מורה ראית השכל**, as in Kohelet: **ולבי ראה הרבה חכמה ודעת** — the heart doesn't see; it perceives. (Moreh, Chapter 4.)

**ופעל ישב נאמר עליו — הוא שלא ישתנה; הישיבה מורה קביעות והנחה על עניין אחד.** (Chapter 11.)

**והכסא מורה על הנהגה והשגחה, ונקרא השמים כסא ה'** — the heavens are His throne because through them one sees His השגחה in the world. (Chapter 9.)

**רם ונשא — רוצה לומר: רם בעצמו, ונשא על ידי אחרים, שהם המשיגים שהוא נעלה על כל עילוי ורוממות.** (Chapter 20 — exactly the distinction made in this shiur.)

And **ושוליו מלאים את ההיכל** (the Malbim doesn't say it, but it follows from Chapter 19): we haven't yet defined **שוליו** or **היכל**, but the Heichal was filled with **perfection**, the third meaning of מלא.

**Before the Moreh**, we read the verse like simpletons: *Uzziyahu died; I saw God sitting on a raised-up chair, and the hem of His robe was filling the Temple.* **Now it reads:** *I had an intellectual vision of Hashem — enduring, permanent; on a throne — in majesty, with His involvement and השגחה; intrinsically exalted, and through this He was lifted up in my mind; and I saw the Heichal filled with perfection.* One verse, six words, twenty chapters — and the whole verse changes.

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## Chapter 21 — עבר: Introduction (Part 1)

Chapter 21 deals with the verb **עבר**, to pass. It is not a long chapter, but there is a great deal to discuss, and to appreciate it we need to revise and go back to the Torah. It's a shame we didn't learn it before Yom Kippur, because it is about the verse we said **26 times on Yom Kippur**, and throughout the forty days of Selichot, and on Mondays and Thursdays (and, for Sephardim, every day):

**ויעבר ה' על פניו ויקרא: ה' ה' אל רחום וחנון...**

## The Story (Shemot 33–34)

After the **sin of the golden calf**, Moshe secures forgiveness. Then:

**ויאמר: הראני נא את כבדך.** (33:18)

*"Show me Your glory."* We haven't yet defined **כבוד**, but we know **ראה** with Hashem means intellectual seeing. So Moshe is asking to grasp something of Hashem intellectually.

**ויאמר: לא תוכל לראות את פני, כי לא יראני האדם וחי.** (33:20)

From Hashem's reply we learn that "show me Your glory" amounted to **"show me Your face"** — intellectually. What that means, we don't know yet.

**ויאמר ה': הנה מקום אתי, ונצבת על הצור.** (33:21)

**Revision:** in this eight-word verse, three words we have already explained:

| Word | Chapter | Meaning |
|---|---|---|
| **מקום** | 8 | An intellectual position or standing, not a geographical place |
| **ונצבת** | 15 | Permanence: stand constantly, firmly |
| **הצור** | 16 | The origin and source of all existence |

So: *You asked to see My face — that I cannot give you. But **there is an intellectual standing with Me** that I can give you: **stand constantly on the Rock** — continually contemplate the origins of everything, the universe, and God.* Nothing new so far.

**והיה בעבר כבדי, ושמתיך בנקרת הצור, ושכתי כפי עליך עד עברי. והסרתי את כפי, וראית את אחרי, ופני לא יראו.** (23–33:22)

**Here is the new word:** *When My glory **passes**, I will put you in the **cleft of the rock**, and **cover you with My palm** until I have **passed**. Then I will take away My palm, and you will see **My back**, but My face will not be seen.* What does "passing" mean with Hashem? What is the cleft, the palm, the back? **That is the subject of Chapter 21**, and by its end these verses will make sense.

Then Moshe carves the second luchot:

**וישכם משה בבקר ויעל אל הר סיני כאשר צוה ה' אתו, ויקח בידו שני לחת אבנים.** (34:4)

**וירד ה' בענן, ויתיצב עמו שם, ויקרא בשם ה'.** (34:5)

**Revision again** — two words we know:

**וירד** (Chapter 10): **resting His Shechinah**, not a physical descent.

**ויתיצב** (Chapters 13/15): **continuity, permanence**.

So Hashem rested His presence with Moshe, and it was a permanent presence; and he called in the name of Hashem.

**ויעבר ה' על פניו ויקרא: ה' ה' אל רחום וחנון, ארך אפים ורב חסד ואמת...** (34:6)

**What does it mean that Hashem "passed"?**

## Four Questions to Hold On To

As we learn Chapter 21, keep these four questions in mind. We will return to all four at the end of the chapter.

**1. What does עבר mean when used of Hashem?** — in **ויעבר ה'**, and earlier in **והיה בעבר כבדי**.

**2. Whose face?** — **ויעבר ה' על פניו**: is it **Moshe's** face, or **Hashem's own** "face"? It could be either. (If it is Hashem's own face, we will have to understand what that means.)

**3. Where does the colon go?** Ask 99% of davening Jews and they will read:

**ויעבר ה' על פניו ויקרא: ה' ה' אל רחום וחנון...**

*Hashem passed before his face and called: "Hashem, Hashem, merciful and gracious God…"*

But it can also be read — and we will see this is **the Rambam's preferred reading**:

**ויעבר ה' על פניו, ויקרא ה': ה' אל רחום וחנון...**

*Hashem passed before his face, and **Hashem called**: "Hashem, merciful and gracious God…"* — the colon comes **after the first ה'**.

**4. How do we count the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy?** This has halachic implications:

- **The Ben Ish Chai** writes that when you say the Thirteen Attributes, you should **count them** as you go: ה' (one), ה' (two), אל (three)…
- **Chacham Ovadia** says **don't**, because you would be entering a **major machloket Rishonim** about how to count them. Is the first ה' one of the thirteen? Is the second?

## What Comes Next

Before answering any of this, the Rambam gives **five meanings of the word עבר**. **Four of the five** are needed to understand the chapter, so they must be understood clearly; that should take the first twenty minutes or so of next week's shiur. Then come **three readings of the verse — which are really four** —

each using a different meaning of עבר: **the Rambam's preferred reading first**, then others he accepts but does not prefer. In each reading, the answers to the four questions change. (The Rabbi expects a chart to help lay it out.)

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## Summary of the Shiur

**Chapter 20: רם** and **נשא** both mean physical height or elevation of status, and of Hashem always status. The Rambam separates them because **רם is intrinsic height** and **נשא is being lifted up by another**; hence נשא also means to forgive and to count, and hence Hashem is **רם** in Himself and **נשא** in our minds through our worship. The many words used to define them all point back to **Hashem's essence**, a theme the Rambam will develop as **negative theology**.

**Revision:** Yeshayahu 6:1 now reads, word by word, through six chapters of the Moreh.

**Chapter 21 (introduction):** Moshe's request **הראני נא את כבדך**, Hashem's answer **הנה מקום אתי ונצבת על הצור**, the cleft, the palm, the back, **וירד ה' בענן ויתיצב עמו שם**, and **ויעבר ה' על פניו ויקרא** — with four questions: what is **עבר**, **whose face**, **where the colon goes**, and **how to count the Thirteen Attributes**.

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## Coming Up

- **Next week: Chapter 21** — the **five meanings of עבר**, then the **three (really four) readings** of **ויעבר ה' על פניו ויקרא**, and the answers to the four questions.
- **Essential preparation:** listen to this whole shiur before next week. The Rabbi will also post a reminder on the group. *"I've been giving shiurim for many, many years — this is essential."*
- Keep reviewing the earlier chapters; everything ties together.

*(The recording ends as Mark begins a question about Chapter 19.)*

*B'Ezrat Hashem*

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